

WHEN I CONQUERED A CHINESE AT THE OLYMPICS

Having played against Lu Lin not long ago, I could **plan a strategy** along with coach Manjit Dua and the Chinese coach Lid Yang. I knew I had to remain at my peak and catch him off guard.

Kamlesh Mehta

Table tennis was introduced into the Olympics in Seoul in 1988. We, as table tennis players, did not realise the importance of Olympics. We knew that the Olympics is a big, big event, but it hadn't really struck. In fact, I was not to go for the qualifications in 1988. The federation asked me to pay for my airfare to Islamabad for the qualification event. I declined and went only after the whole issue was sorted out and qualified as well.

In 1992, once the importance had been underlined being an Olympic sport, there was a lot more focus from the government, and even the media. I remember before I went to the Olympics, there were so many people covering my training regime and all. That had never happened for any of the TT-related important events. The attention was different, so 1992 in that way was different. Even the qualification process was

different from the one we had for 1988. It was very difficult to qualify since each group had six players from nine previously and depending on the overall standings, the highest-placed player from each country was assured of an automatic qualification and had the option of choosing the doubles partner.

Asia being a table tennis powerhouse, the qualification field was very challenging. I had a good

outing, especially the win against a dominant Chiang Peng-Lung from Chinese Taipei that ensured a direct qualification and Chetan (Baboor) also earned the ticket. **I then chose my old mate and partner Sujay Ghorpade as the doubles partner so the three of us went to Barcelona.**

There was no specific team camp for the Olympics in India. I trained abroad for a while before joining Sujay and Chetan in Barcelona.



Lu Lin covered up quite a bit in the second game but the last service was in my hand at 20-15. He was attacking everything that was coming his way, so I literally served a simple service – a beginner's service – and he hit it too hard and it went long.